

Students fear a trap in financial aid form

Will a blank Social Security entry expose parents living in the U.S. illegally? Families face a tough choice.

By JAWED KALEEM

A few days before winter break, Lynda McGee, a college counselor at Downtown Magnets High School in Los Angeles Unified, got an unexpected visit from a student's father.

The man, a warehouse worker who emigrated from Guatemala 28 years ago, wanted to make sure that McGee knew his wishes firsthand.

"My daughter going to college is more important than my risk of deportation," he said in Spanish as the student, a high school senior, translated.

He insisted that McGee help the teen, a U.S.-born citizen, fill out the FAFSA, or the Free Application for Federal Student Aid, which is used to calculate all-important financial aid packages for college-bound students. But the application asks for parents' Social Security numbers, which the father does not have because he is not a legal resident. A missing number could be a red flag about the father's immigration status ahead of the inauguration of President-elect Donald Trump, who has vowed to track down and deport undocumented immigrants.

"Unfortunately, I have dozens of students in this same situation," McGee said. "They have to choose between their future and that of their parents."

Submitting financial aid forms this college application season has become a potentially life-altering family decision for California high school seniors with undocumented parents — a predicament also faced by many college students because FAFSA forms generally must be submitted annually to determine ongoing aid.

[See FAFSA, A5]

Russian gas flow to Europe ends
Targeting Moscow's finances, Ukraine refuses to extend a prewar transit deal for its pipelines. **WORLD, A3**

OD deaths drop in San Francisco
Experts credit better access to treatment and the COVID recovery with 24% decrease in 2024. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Ohio State rolls in Rose Bowl
For more on the Buckeyes' big playoff win, visit [latimes.com/enewspaper](#) or [latimes.com/sports](#).

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 76/52. **B6**

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AN ACROBAT flies high over a trampoline during the 2025 Rose Parade Opening Spectacular in Pasadena on New Year's Day.

Joy, tragedy ring in new year

Thousands attend the 136th Rose Parade, with thoughts on New Orleans

By CONNOR SHEETS, JASMINE MENDEZ, HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS AND JUSTINO AGUILA

After patrolling the Rose Parade for decades as members of the Pasadena Police Department, Keith and Shelley Jones joked that they'd had their fill of the petals and pageantry and would never return.

But on Wednesday morning, there they were — hanging out in the grandstands along Colorado Boulevard, just as giddy about the floats and marching bands as their two young grandchildren at their sides.

"It's a New Year's tradition for us. ... We all love it all," said Shelley Jones, 72.

The Joneses, of La Verne, bring their grandchildren, ages 8 and 10, to the parade each year while their daughter and son-in-law — who are a Pasadena police detective and lieutenant, respectively — help provide security for the event.



THE 605 ALL-STAR BAND participates in the 136th Rose Parade as it rolls down Colorado Boulevard in Pasadena.

And while the 136th Rose Parade was a joyous occasion for the family, they were thinking of New Orleans, where, just hours earlier, a driver plowed into a crowd along Bourbon Street, killing at least 15 people and injuring dozens in a suspected terrorist attack.

"It's a tragedy," said Keith Jones, 70. "It's very much a shame. You feel for the families. Security has always been a concern, it's always front of mind, but it's definitely ramped up since 9/11."

Nevertheless, Jones, who sported a pair of shorts and a puffy jacket, said he felt safe at the Rose Parade because of the major law enforcement presence.

Security was top of mind for Pasadena and Tournament of Roses officials on Wednesday as hundreds of thousands of people lined the 5.5-mile route beneath picture-perfect blue skies, celebrating this year's parade theme of "Best Day Ever."

Tournament of Roses officials [See Rose Parade, A10]



THE DRIVER was an Army veteran from Texas who was killed in a shootout with police that injured two officers. Many in the crowd were critically hurt.

Truck drives into New Orleans crowd, killing 15; FBI investigates as terrorism

By ERIC TUCKER, JIM MUSTIAN, KEVIN MCGILL AND GERALD HERBERT

NEW ORLEANS — An Army veteran driving a pickup truck that bore the flag of the Islamic State

group wrought carnage on New Orleans' raucous New Year's celebration, killing at least 15 people as he steered around a police blockade and slammed into revelers before being shot dead by police.

The FBI said it was investigating the attack early

Wednesday in the city's French Quarter as a terrorist act and did not believe the driver acted alone.

President Biden said Wednesday evening that the FBI found videos that the driver had posted to social media hours before the attack [See New Orleans, A5]

Lawsuit threatens Verdugo Mountains conservation efforts

For a year and a half, No Canyon Hills has protested a 300-acre development. Now, the developer is suing.

By JACK FLEMMING

The latest chapter in the saga of a 300-acre development in the Verdugo Mountains revolves around surveillance cameras and native bumblebees. The developer is suing protesters for trespassing onto the property in attempts to gather evidence for why the land should be preserved.

Nevada-based developer Whitebird Inc. has grandiose visions for the luxury complex known as Canyon Hills. The project would transform the rugged hillside above the Sunland-Tujunga neighborhood, which has largely been spared from development, into a tony community with 221 homes.

The development was approved by the Los Angeles City Council in 2005 with a 20-year window of completion running through October 2026.

Multiple groups have protested the project in the two decades since. Locals worry that it would bring overpopulation and traffic to the rural community. Environmentalists claimed the homes would be unsafe in the fire-prone mountains.

Whitebird reined in the scope as a result, bringing the footprint from 900 acres down to 300 and donating the remaining 600 acres to be preserved as open space. But activists argue that 300 acres of development is still too much.

The latest group to protest, No Canyon Hills, formed in spring 2023 as a collection of artists, designers and amateur botanists who say the area's native flora and wildlife are worth protecting.

Now, with the closing of [See Development, A7]



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